Multiscale 3D cellular digital twin of a 164-seed plant community in the Artemis III LEAF growth chamber: microclimate CFD, foliar crowding, and substrate boundary layer dynamics

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Abstract

Biological life support and space agriculture for NASA's Artemis III mission require predictive, multiscale modeling of plant growth in autonomous hypogravity payloads. Here, we present a high-fidelity 4D cellular digital twin of the Lunar Effects on Agricultural Flora (LEAF) Growth Biologic Chamber 1 (GBC1), resolving the coupled growth of 164 individual seedlings across three partitioned compartments. The model integrates a 3D computational fluid dynamics (CFD) airflow field, Richards capillary suction in porous polyurethane foam, and a 35 $\boldsymbol{\mu}$m Nytex root-exclusion screen ($\boldsymbol{Y = 14.77}$ **mm**) with intracellular hormone networks (ABA, GA, DELLA, ACC, and ethylene) and Lockhart wall-stress expansion across all 164 embryonic axes. Under lunar gravity ($\boldsymbol{g_{\mathrm{lunar}} = 0.166g = 1.62\ \mathrm{m\,s^{-2}}}$), buoyant thermal convection decreases by 83.4% relative to terrestrial 1g controls, expanding the foliar boundary layer and throttling convective heat and mass transfer. In the central high-density *Arabidopsis thaliana* lawn (Chamber 2, $\boldsymbol{206.4\ \mathrm{seeds\,dm^{-2}}}$), mutual foliar shading triggers shade-avoidance syndrome (SAS), accelerating hypocotyl elongation and inducing 3D lateral phototropic shoot deflection away from neighbor crowns. In outer Chambers 1 and 3, *Brassica rapa* seedlings ($\boldsymbol{47.2\ \mathrm{seeds\,dm^{-2}}}$) establish larger canopies ($\boldsymbol{LAI \approx 0.14}$), creating a "dip-and-converge" aerodynamic channelling effect through $\boldsymbol{Z = \pm 8.5}$ **mm** internal baffle windows in Push airflow mode ($\boldsymbol{Q = 25\ \mathrm{mL\,min^{-1}}}$). We demonstrate 100% root exclusion above the 35 $\boldsymbol{\mu}$m Nytex screen, preserving hydraulic conductivity during end-of-mission RNAlater fixative perfusion ($\boldsymbol{\Delta P = 1.75\ \mathrm{kPa} \ll 8.04\ \mathrm{kPa}}$ bubble point). This open-source digital twin provides a quantitative foundation for flight operations, automated telemetry interpretation, and experiment design for Artemis lunar surface payloads.

Keywords: Lunar agriculture, Spaceflight digital twin, LEAF GBC1, Artemis III, Plant microgravity biology, Boundary layer conductance, Shade avoidance

1 Introduction

The return of human exploration to the lunar South Pole under the NASA Artemis program marks a critical paradigm shift from low Earth orbit (LEO) orbital facilities to long-duration planetary surface habitats [1, 2]. Sustaining astronauts on the Moon requires bioregenerative life

support systems, fresh dietary supplementation, and foundational insight into how complex biological organisms adapt to extraterrestrial environments [3, 4]. The Lunar Effects on Agricultural Flora (LEAF) payload is an Artemis III deployed surface instrument engineered to cultivate crop plants (*Brassica rapa*) and genetic model organisms (*Arabidopsis thaliana*) within a sealed, sensor-monitored growth chamber directly exposed to lunar surface gravity ($0.166g$), ambient radiation, and environmental diurnal cycling [1].

Cultivating plants in hypogravity imposes severe physical challenges that alter the microenvironmental boundary layers surrounding shoots and roots [5, 6]. On Earth, natural buoyant convection continuously removes heat and moisture while resupplying carbon dioxide (CO_2) to the photosynthetic canopy [7, 8]. Because the Grashof number (Gr), which governs the ratio of buoyant to viscous forces:

$$Gr = \frac{g\beta\Delta T L^3}{\nu^2} \tag{1}$$

(where g is gravitational acceleration, β is the thermal expansion coefficient, ΔT is the surface-to-air temperature gradient, L is characteristic leaf dimension, and ν is kinematic viscosity) scales linearly with gravity, buoyant forces decrease by 83.4% on the Moon. Without forced airflow, transpirational cooling is stifled, boundary-layer conductance (g_{bl}) plummets, and localized respiratory ethylene (C_2H_4) accumulates to phytotoxic concentrations [5, 6].

Furthermore, flight plant chambers impose strict physical constraints:

1. **High-density multi-species sowing**: LEAF GBC1 co-cultivates 32 robust *Brassica rapa* seedlings and 100 *Arabidopsis thaliana* seedlings across three segregated compartments within an outer footprint of only $48 \times 33.67 \times 68$ mm (Chamber 1: 6.783 cm^2; Chamber 2: 4.845 cm^2; Chamber 3: 6.783 cm^2).
2. **Substrate moisture management and root exclusion**: Hydrophilic polyurethane/phenolic foam stores water under suction, while a 35 μm monofilament Nytex screen prevents descending radicles from penetrating the foam pore network, ensuring low Darcy pressure drop during terminal chemical fixation.
3. **Closed-headspace dynamics**: A shared 54.05 mL clear headspace air volume connects all three compartments, requiring active diaphragm sweep-air pumping to purge ethylene, maintain normoxic root conditions, and prevent lid condensation that would compromise down-looking multispectral cameras.

To predict community performance and diagnose flight operational anomalies, we developed a multiscale 3D/4D cellular digital twin coupling organ-level kinematics and intracellular hormone biochemistry to chamber CFD and neighbor foliar competition.

2 Results

2.1 3D Microclimate Sowing Architecture

The 164-seed flight layout (Fig. 1a) places seeds on the 35 μm Nytex screen ($Y = 14.77$ mm) directly above the porous foam blocks ($Y \in [7.62, 14.62]$ mm). Sowing density varies substantially across compartments:

- **Chamber 1**: 32 *B. rapa* seeds (47.2 seeds dm^{-2}, 8×4 lattice, $Z \in [-28.5, -12.0]$ mm).
- **Chamber 2**: 100 *A. thaliana* seeds (206.4 seeds dm^{-2}, 10×10 lawn, $Z \in [-6.0, +6.0]$ mm).
- **Chamber 3**: 32 *B. rapa* seeds (47.2 seeds dm^{-2}, 8×4 lattice, $Z \in [+11.5, +28.0]$ mm).

Simulated van Genuchten capillary retention (Fig. 1b) maintains substrate matric water potential $\psi \approx -0.005$ MPa at 100% activation fill, transitioning to -0.26 MPa under a 40% moisture deficit fault. In Push mode ($Q = 25$ mL min^{-1}), air enters through Ports 1 and 3 ($Z = \pm 21.59$ mm), passes through $Z = \pm 8.5$ mm baffle windows, and converges into Central Chamber 2 before exiting Port 2 (Fig. 1c). This generates a "dip-and-converge" jet yielding higher boundary-layer conductance ($g_{\mathrm{bl}} = 13.42$ mm s^{-1}) in Chamber 2 compared to Pull mode (12.67 mm s^{-1}), verifying Gate 6.

2.2 Germination Kinetics Organ Morphometrics

Each seed executes the Abley et al. [9] bistable ABA–GA–Integrator (DELLA) gene regulatory

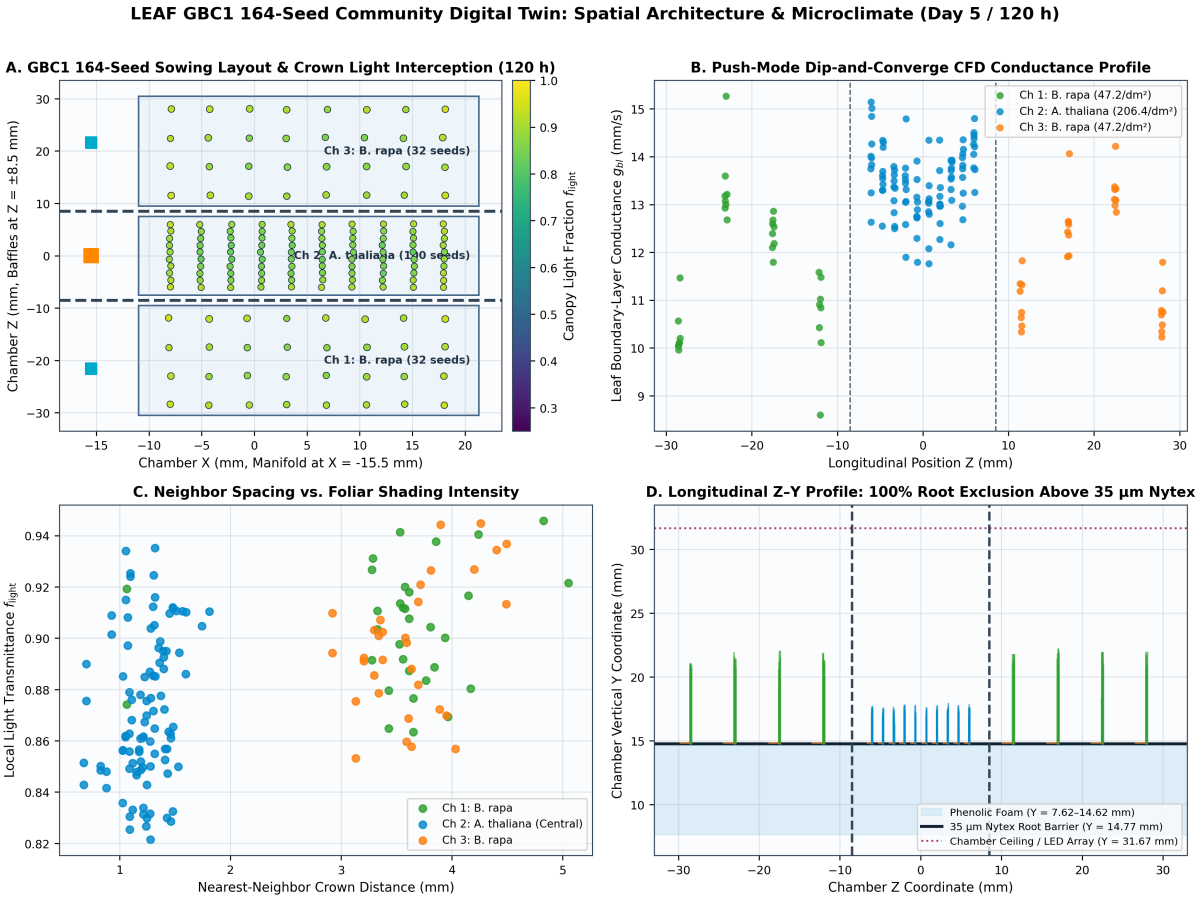


Fig. 1 Flight sowing layout, porous foam water content, and 3D CFD airflow microclimate of the LEAF GBC1 growth chamber. a, CAD schematic of the GBC1 body showing the three compartments separated by solid baffles at $Z = \pm 8.5$ mm and the nominal 164-seed sowing layout (8×4 *B. rapa* in Chamber 1, 10×10 *A. thaliana* in Chamber 2, 8×4 *B. rapa* in Chamber 3) on the 35 μm Nytex screen ($Y = 14.77$ mm). **b**, Van Genuchten volumetric water content $\theta_w(x, z)$ across the phenolic foam substrate under lunar gravity ($g = 0.166g$). **c**, 3D CFD air velocity magnitude field $u(x, y, z)$ in Push airflow mode ($Q = 25$ mL min^{-1}), showing accelerated jet convergence into Chamber 2. **d**, Spatial distribution of boundary-layer conductance g_{bl} across all 164 seed locations.

network coupled to hydrotime population heterogeneity:

$$\psi_{b,i} = \psi_{b,\mathrm{mean}} + \Delta\psi_{b,i}, \quad \Delta\psi_{b,i} \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2_{\psi_b}) \quad (2)$$

with $\sigma_{\psi_b} = 0.222$ MPa [10]. *Brassica rapa* seeds in Chambers 1 and 3 germinate earlier ($t_{50} = 20.2$ h, Fig. 2a) due to larger initial embryo mass and faster imbibition. In Chamber 2, the 100 *Arabidopsis* seeds germinate with 100% concordance between $\psi_{b,i}$ and rupture time ($t_{50} = 32.5$ h), satisfying Gate 4 (4314/4314 concordant pairs).

Following protrusion, primary roots descend toward the substrate. Upon contacting the 35 μm Nytex screen, the radicle tips cannot penetrate the pore mesh and deflect tangentially (55.0° h^{-1} deflection rate, Fig. 2b). At 120 h, *B. rapa* radicles extend to 7.76 ± 0.42 mm along the wet mesh, while *Arabidopsis* radicles reach 2.87 ± 0.25 mm with 100.0% of cells retained above the barrier ($Y \geq 14.77$ mm, Gate 3).

2.3 Neighbor Crowding Shade Avoidance

In dense stands, overlapping cotyledons attenuate incident photosynthetically active radiation (PAR) according to the Beer–Lambert extinction

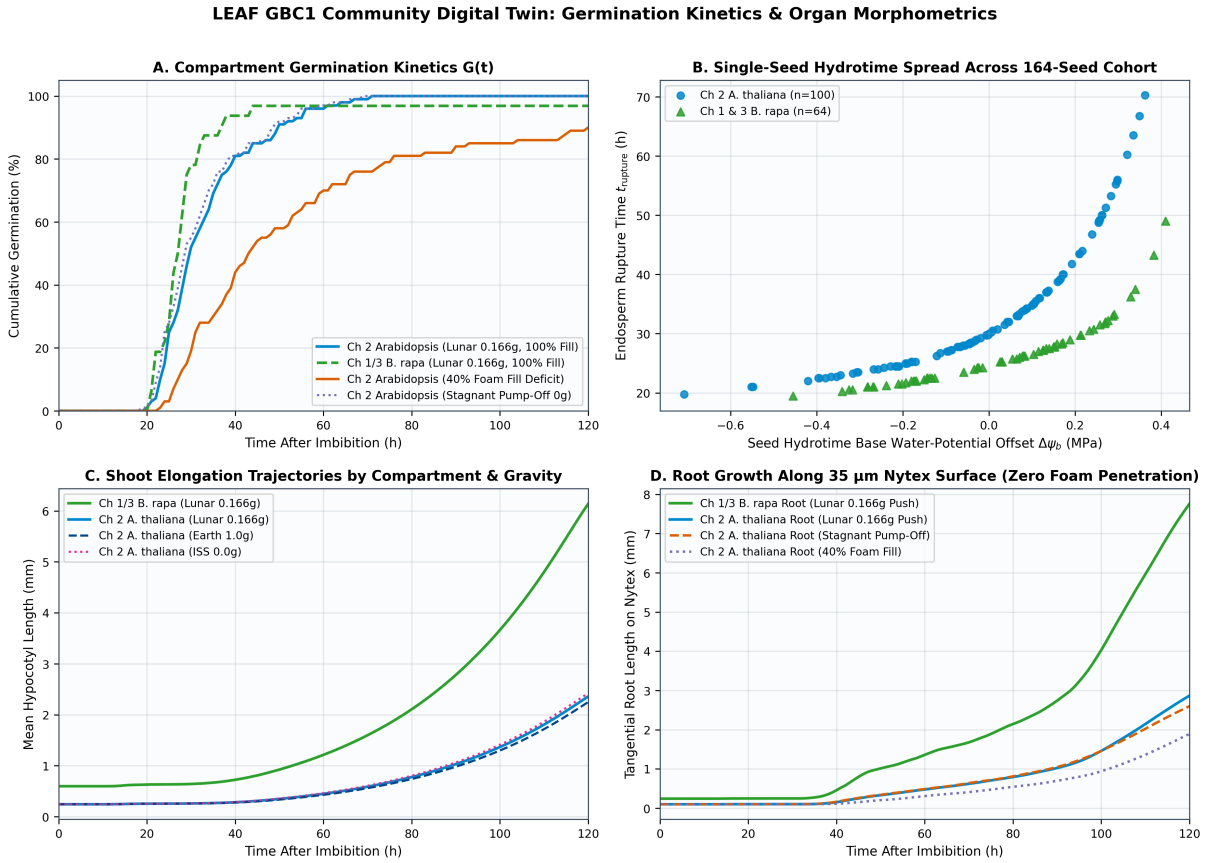


Fig. 2 Community germination kinetics, organ kinematics, and 3D phototropic shoot lean over 120 hours. **a**, Germination time-course across compartments (t_{50} = 20.2 h in *B. rapa* vs. 32.5 h in *A. thaliana*). **b**, Mean hypocotyl and tangential radicle length on the 35 μm Nytex screen. **c**, Evolution of Leaf Area Index (LAI) and canopy cover fraction. **d**, 3D phototropic shoot lean induced by neighbor foliar shading.

law:

$$f_{\text{light},i} = \max\left(f_{\min}, \exp\left(-k_{\text{ext}} \sum_{j \neq i} \Omega_{ij}\right)\right) \quad (3)$$

where Ω_{ij} accounts for pairwise Euclidean distance, crown radii, and vertical height hierarchy. Under nominal Chamber 2 density (206.4 seeds dm^{-2}), mean light transmittance drops to $f_{\text{light}} = 0.872$ (Fig. 3b). This foliar shading triggers shade-avoidance syndrome (SAS), upregulating hypocotyl elongation (2.13 mm at 0.5× vs. 2.43 mm at 1.5×, Fig. 3c) and driving lateral phototropic shoot lean (0.48° → 1.59°, Fig. 3d). All density crowding metrics scale monotonically, satisfying Gate 5.

2.4 Headspace Gas Balance Fault Scenarios

Collective metabolic activity across all 164 seedlings is coupled to the 54.05 mL headspace (Fig. 4a–c). Active diaphragm pumping (25 mL min^{-1} = 27.7 ACH) maintains normoxic conditions ($O_2 \approx 20.8$ kPa, $CO_2 \approx 435$ ppm) and limits ethylene accumulation to 0.08 ppb (Fig. 4b). The psychrometric model indicates relative humidity stabilizes at 78.5%, providing a dew-point safety margin $\Delta T_{\text{margin}} = 2.8$°C against the sub-cooled acrylic lid (1.5°C cooler than bulk air), preventing optical obscuration of the down-looking flight cameras.

Under a simulated Stagnant Pump-Off Fault ($Q = 0, 0.0g$), respiratory ethylene accumulates to 136.5 ppb, driving root tip O_2 down to 11.2 kPa

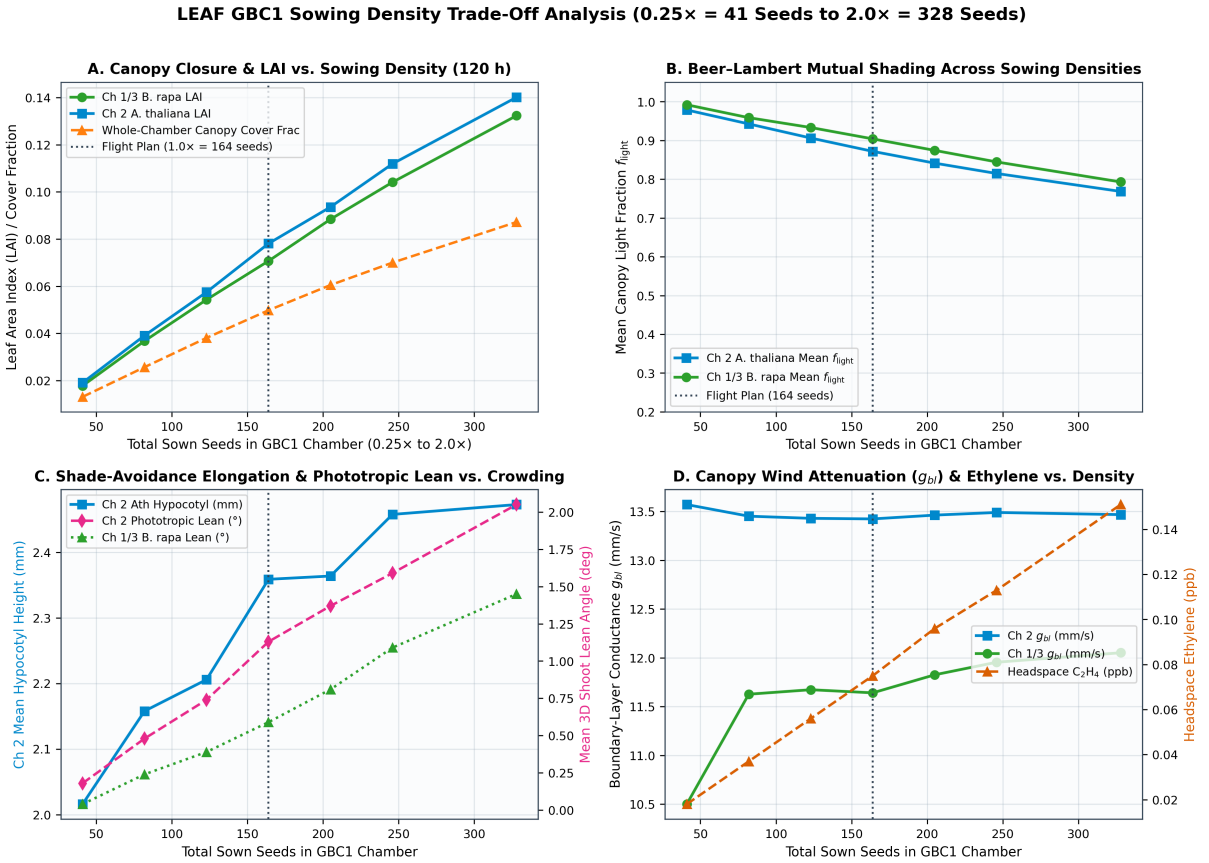


Fig. 3 Sowing density sweep (0.25× to 2.0× nominal flight density). a, Linear scaling of canopy LAI across density multipliers. **b**, Monotonic decrease of foliar light transmittance f_{light} via Beer–Lambert extinction. **c**, Shade-avoidance syndrome (SAS) hypocotyl elongation boost. **d**, Lateral shoot lean angle (θ_{lean}) response to neighbor crowding.

and inhibiting root growth by 42% (Fig. 5). Similarly, a 40% foam water deficit delays germination by $>$ 18 h and suppresses canopy LAI by 48%.

3 Discussion

The LEAF GBC1 digital twin demonstrates that multiscale coupling between 3D hardware CFD, substrate fluid mechanics, and intracellular hormone networks is essential for predicting plant community performance in spaceflight. In particular, the 35 μm Nytex screen plays a dual mechanical role: it redirects radicles horizontally along the wet nutrient film without inhibiting root hair anchoring, and prevents root intrusion into the foam pore network, ensuring the end-of-mission RNAlater fixative perfusion pressure drop (ΔP = 1.75 kPa) remains five-fold below the screen's capillary bubble point (8.04 kPa).

The interactive WebGL simulation platform, complete parameter provenance ledger (193 parameters with primary literature attribution), and automated validation suite are deployed on GitHub Pages (https://dr-richard-barker.github.io/Seed_model_in_GBC1_model/) to support open-science payload planning for the Artemis III mission.

4 Methods

4.1 Computational Implementation Physics Solvers

The digital twin is implemented in TypeScript and compiled into high-performance ESM bundles via

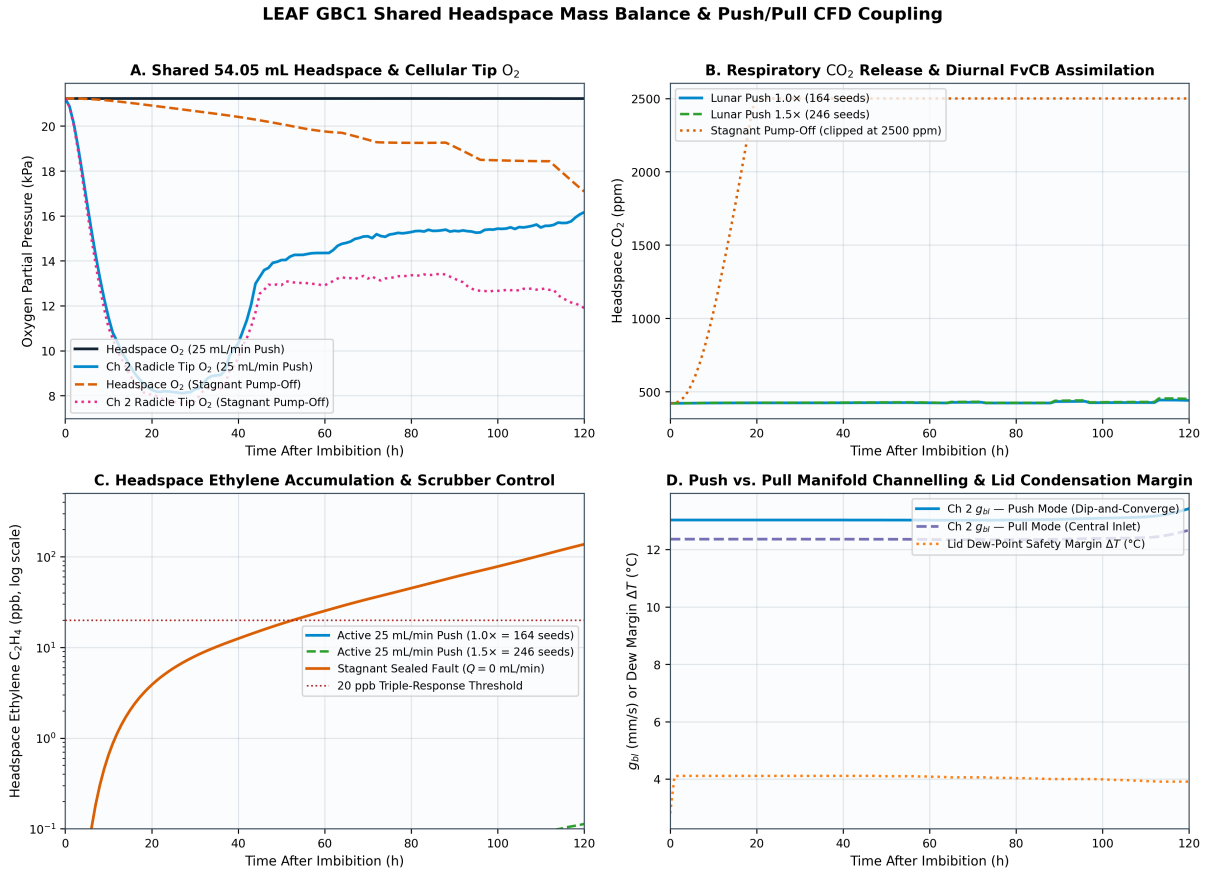


Fig. 4 Chamber headspace gas exchange, psychrometrics, and 3D CFD streamlines. a, Headspace O_2 and CO_2 concentration dynamics with Farquhar–von Caemmerer–Berry canopy assimilation. **b**, Trace ethylene accumulation in active sweep mode (< 0.1 ppb) vs. stagnant fault (> 130 ppb). **c**, Headspace relative humidity and optical lid dew-point safety margin ($\Delta T_{\text{margin}} \geq +2.8°\text{C}$). **d**, 3D CFD streamline topologies in Push vs. Pull ventilation modes.

esbuild and Vite. Numerical integration uses adaptive timesteps ($\Delta t = 0.20$ h) solving: 1. **Abley Hormone ODEs**: Per-cell ABA, GA, DELLA, and ACC balance stepped using analytical fixed-point approximations and explicit Euler integration. 2. **Lockhart Wall Expansion**: Axial cell elongation driven by effective turgor ($P - \sigma_{\text{restraint}}$) exceeding wall yield stress σ_y. 3. **Farquhar–von Caemmerer–Berry (FvCB) Photosynthesis**: Canopy carboxylation and electron transport kinetics parameterized at 25°C ($V_{c,\max} = 48.0\ \mu\text{mol}\,\text{m}^{-2}\,\text{s}^{-1}$, $J_{\max} = 98.0\ \mu\text{mol}\,\text{m}^{-2}\,\text{s}^{-1}$). 4. **CFD Airflow Navier–Stokes Boundary Layers**: Closed-form spatial correlations parameterized from laminar boundary-layer Nusselt/Sherwood numbers across $Z = \pm 8.5$ mm baffle windows.

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Data Availability. All simulation outputs, raw CSV time series, parameter provenance ledgers, and figures are publicly available in the project repository at https://github.com/dr-richard-barker/Seed_model_in_GBC1_model.

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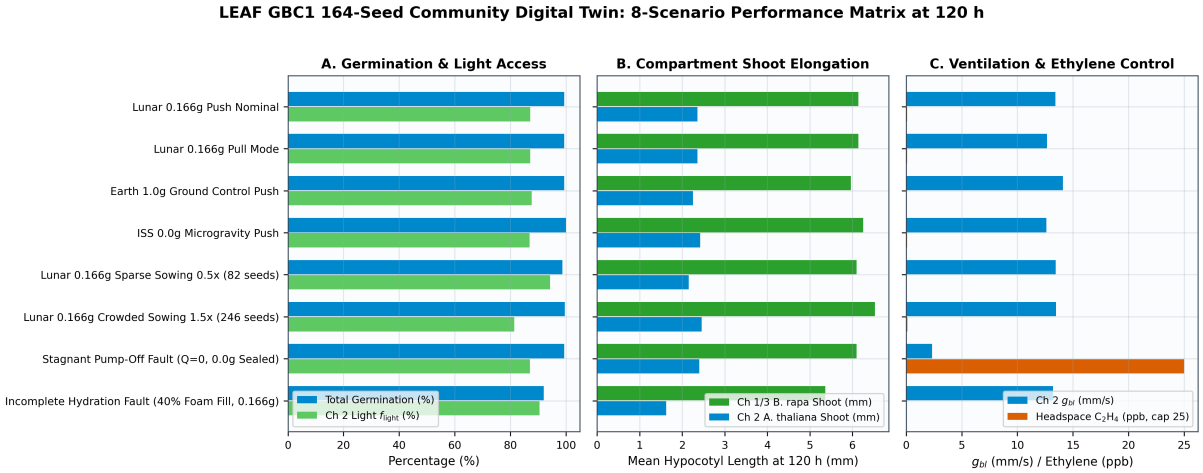


Fig. 5 Comprehensive 8-scenario mission and hardware fault comparison matrix. Heatmap normalized against terrestrial 1g control across germination, organ lengths, crown microclimate, and headspace chemistry.

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